unselfconscious in his merriment as he was in his anger. ‘When he laughs,’ writes the priest, ‘his face becomes almost distorted.’

Abul Fazl describes a scene from one of Akbar’s early elephant hunts that had Akbar and his men in splits. A man called Shah Fakhruddin was thrown off his horse by a wild she-elephant. When the other hunters arrived to his rescue, Fakhruddin ‘in his confusion, lost his head and put his finger on his mouth as a sign to them to be silent’. The memory of the dazed man’s desperate ‘Shh!’ to keep a dangerous beast at bay was a ‘source of amusement’ for a long time, writes Abul Fazl – Akbar must have remembered and retold it decades later, still chuckling perhaps, for his scribe to write the story.

For all his sense of humour, it isn’t clear whether Akbar approved of frivolous behaviour by his mansabdars. ‘A king should not be familiar in mirth and amusement with his courtiers’ was one of Akbar’s Happy Sayings, in fact. The *Akbarnama* includes a passing mention of a man called Jafar Beg who was imprisoned alongside Muzaffar Khan during the upheavals in Bengal. Unlike the poor governor, Jafar Beg managed to escape by virtue of his wit, ‘joking and making light of the situation’. This was apt, Abul Fazl implies: Jafar Beg had been exiled to Bengal for making unseemly jokes in court.[19]

Birbar, by contrast, is among the few men who never suffered a rebuke from Akbar. Only once is there even a hint of Birbar getting into trouble with the emperor. Badauni tells of how Akbar, in one of his many social innovations, had instructed the prostitutes of Fatehpur to name any amir who visited and ‘seduced’ them, so the emperor might have the wretched man punished. Birbar’s was one of the names the women gave up. The poet was distraught; he threatened to give up life in court and wander the streets as a yogi. And far from punishing him, Akbar mollified his friend.

They influenced each other, too. Birbar made no objection, for example to joining Akbar’s circle of disciples; both Akbar and his mother Hamida began to patronize Vaishnavism and a well-known philosopher of the school called Vithalnath thanks to Birbar’s interest in the sect.[20]

Perhaps there is no point seeking reasons for Akbar’s affection; or perhaps the friendship between the emperor and the poet had the same foundation as any lasting relationship. Trust.